Enforce least-privilege access through identity-aware, application-specific access policies using Zscaler Private Access (ZPA).

Title of the project :

Enforce least-privilege access through identity-aware, application-specific access policies using Zscaler Private Access (ZPA).

S.no	Name	College	Contact
1	SRI GOKULAVANI N	Sri Krishna Adithya College of Arts and Science	23bsct161srigokulavanin@skacas.ac.in
2	SANJEEV KUMAR D	Sri Krishna Adithya College of Arts and Science	23bsct155sanjeevkumard@skacas.ac.in
3	SACHIN S	Sri Krishna Adithya College of Arts and Science	23bsct145sachins@skacas.ac.in
4	MANIVEL RAJA R	Sri Krishna Adithya College of Arts and Science	23bsct127manivelrajar@skacas.ac.in

INTRODUCTION:

As the digital environment continues to evolve, organizations are increasingly exposed to sophisticated cyber threats. This growing risk highlights the critical need for rapid and efficient incident response mechanisms to protect sensitive information, secure digital infrastructure, and maintain stakeholder confidence. To address these challenges, this project proposes the development of an AI-powered incident response platform designed to support cybersecurity teams by automating incident triage and improving the efficiency of response activities.

With the rise of cloud computing and remote work, the traditional network perimeter has become less defined, making legacy VPN-based remote access models less effective. These conventional systems often provide broad network-level access, which increases the attack surface and allows potential attackers to move laterally within the network. To overcome these limitations, this project adopts a Zero Trust security architecture, built on the principle of “never trust, always verify.” Instead of relying on network location to determine trust, access decisions are made based on identity, device posture, and contextual factors.

A key component of this approach is the implementation of Zscaler Private Access (ZPA), a cloud-based Zero Trust Access solution that enables secure, application-level connectivity. Unlike traditional VPNs that place users inside the corporate network, ZPA creates secure, direct connections between authenticated users and the specific applications they are authorized to use. This service-initiated architecture hides internal networks and IP addresses from the internet, ensuring that applications remain invisible to unauthorized users while protecting them from threats such as port scanning and distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attacks.

The solution also enforces a strict least-privilege access model, ensuring that users and devices receive only the minimum permissions required to perform their roles. By separating application access from network access, the system prevents users from viewing or interacting with other network resources, thereby eliminating opportunities for lateral movement within the environment. This strategy significantly strengthens the organization’s security posture, reduces the overall attack surface, and simplifies access management while providing a more seamless experience for users.

ABSTRACT

The rapid expansion of hybrid work environments and cloud services has reduced the effectiveness of traditional perimeter-based security systems such as Virtual Private Networks (VPNs). These legacy approaches typically grant users broad access to internal networks, which increases security risks such as lateral threat movement and a larger attack surface. This project addresses these challenges by implementing a Zero Trust Architecture (ZTA) using Zscaler Private Access (ZPA). The main goal is to replace the traditional network-based access model with an identity-based approach that enforces the principle of least privilege.

The proposed solution deploys ZPA's cloud-based platform to create secure, application-level connections through identity-aware micro-tunnels. Unlike conventional VPNs that connect users directly to the internal network, this system establishes secure one-to-one connections between authenticated users and specific authorized applications. As a result, the internal network and other unauthorized resources remain hidden from users, significantly reducing opportunities for reconnaissance and cyberattacks. Access policies are dynamically applied based on user identity, device security posture, and contextual factors, ensuring that users can only access the resources necessary for their job roles.

By implementing ZPA, the project effectively separates application access from overall network access, resulting in a reduced attack surface and preventing lateral movement within the network. The solution provides a secure, scalable, and efficient remote access framework that aligns with modern cybersecurity best practices. Adopting this identity-centered, least-privilege access model improves the organization's security posture while also simplifying management and enhancing the user experience.

USE CASE SCENARIOS

Scenario 1: Finance Department Access to ERP System

A senior accountant from the finance team needs remote access to the organization's Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) system to complete monthly payroll activities. The employee connects using a company-issued laptop from an external location. After launching the ZPA Client Connector, the user authenticates through Microsoft Azure Active Directory using multi-factor authentication. The Zero Trust policy engine evaluates multiple factors such as the user's identity, membership in the Finance_ERP_Users group, device security status (active antivirus and enabled disk encryption), and connection context. Once verification is successful, Zscaler Private Access establishes a secure micro-tunnel directly to the ERP application. The user is able to perform required payroll tasks while remaining completely isolated from other internal systems such as development environments or HR databases.

OUTPUT

- Successful authentication based on identity and group membership
- Secure micro-tunnel created only for the ERP application
- Other internal resources remain hidden and inaccessible

Scenario 2: Contractor Access to a Project Repository

An external consultant is hired for a temporary software development project and needs access to a specific internal Git repository. The contractor is registered as a guest user in the identity management system and placed in the "Project_X_Contractors" group. When connecting through the ZPA client, the system verifies the user's credentials and evaluates the device's security posture, including operating system patch status and firewall configuration. Based on predefined policies in Zscaler Private Access, the contractor is allowed to access only the designated Git repository via SSH (port 22) or HTTPS (port 443) during working hours. The consultant can perform repository operations such as cloning and pushing code but is unable to access other internal services like file servers or the corporate intranet.

Output

- Access limited by role and working hours
- Contractor restricted to a single application resource
- Lateral movement across internal systems prevented

Scenario 3: Executive Access to Confidential Board Documents

A company executive needs to review confidential board meeting documents stored on an internal file server while traveling abroad. The executive connects using a tablet device. The system integrates with the organization's mobile device management platform to verify that the device meets compliance requirements, including encryption, passcode protection, and absence of jailbreak modifications. After successful authentication, the Zero Trust policy evaluates conditions such as membership in the "Executive_Board" group, device compliance status, and connection from an approved geographic region. If these conditions are satisfied, Zscaler Private Access provides a secure connection to the "Board_Documents" file share. Data transmission occurs through encrypted TLS channels, while attempts to access other network resources are blocked and recorded for auditing.

Output

- Context-aware authorization based on identity, device compliance, and location
- Controlled access to the confidential document repository
- Detailed activity logging for compliance and auditing

Scenario 4: IT Administrator Access to Server Management Interfaces

A system administrator must access server management interfaces to perform routine system maintenance. Instead of using a traditional VPN that exposes the entire management network, the organization configures Zscaler Private Access to treat each server management interface as an independent application segment. The administrator authenticates and is presented only with servers that match their assigned role, such as Linux servers for the "Linux_Admins" group or Windows servers for the "Windows_Admins" group. When the administrator connects to a Linux server via SSH or a Windows server through RDP, ZPA establishes a

secure micro-tunnel to the exact server and port required. This prevents the administrator from scanning the network or accessing unauthorized systems.

OUTPUT

- Fine-grained micro-segmentation at the server level
- Role-based access to specific administrative interfaces
- Network scanning and reconnaissance capabilities eliminated

Scenario 5: Mergers and Acquisitions Integration

After acquiring a smaller company, the parent organization must temporarily provide the new HR team access to its internal employee benefits enrollment application. Users from the acquired company are added as external collaborators in the identity provider and assigned to the “Acquired_HR” group. Access policies in Zscaler Private Access allow these users to connect only to the internal Benefits_App web application. Once authenticated through the ZPA client, users are granted direct application-level access without exposure to the broader corporate network. They cannot scan, ping, or interact with other internal systems. After the six-month transition period, the temporary access policy is removed, completing the integration process securely.

Output

- Temporary application-specific access for external collaborators
- Internal network remains hidden from external users
- Access easily revoked through policy updates rather than infrastructure changes

STAGE – 1

TITLE: Enforce least-privilege access through identity-aware, application-specific access policies using Zscaler Private Access (ZPA).

Overview

As cyber threats continue to grow in complexity and frequency, organizations must adopt more advanced security strategies to protect their digital infrastructure. At the same time, the traditional network perimeter has become less relevant due to the rise of cloud services, mobile devices, and remote work. Conventional VPN-based remote access solutions often provide users with broad network access, which increases the attack surface and allows potential attackers to move laterally within the system once access is gained. To address these challenges, this project focuses on implementing a Zero Trust security architecture, which operates on the principle of "never trust, always verify." Rather than relying on network location as a measure of trust, access decisions are based on verified identity, device security status, and contextual factors.

A key component of this project is the deployment of Zscaler Private Access, a cloud-delivered Zero Trust Access solution that enables secure, application-level connectivity. Unlike traditional VPN solutions that connect users directly to the internal network, ZPA creates secure and direct connections between authenticated users and the specific applications they are authorized to access. This service-initiated architecture ensures that internal networks and IP addresses remain hidden from the public internet. As a result, applications become invisible to unauthorized users, effectively reducing exposure to threats such as port scanning and distributed denial-of-service attacks.

The project also implements a least-privilege access model, ensuring that users and devices receive only the permissions required to perform their assigned tasks. By separating application access from network-level access, the solution prevents users from discovering or interacting with other internal resources. This approach significantly limits opportunities for lateral movement within the network. Overall, the adoption of Zero Trust access through ZPA strengthens the organization's security posture, reduces the overall attack surface, improves the user experience, and minimizes the operational burden associated with maintaining traditional remote access infrastructure.

List of Vulnerability

S. No.	Vulnerability Name	CWE No.
1.	Improper Limitation of a Pathname to a Restricted Directory	22
2.	Unimplemented or Unsupported Feature in UI	447
3.	Weak Encoding for Password	261
4.	Improper Input Validation	20
5.	External Control of File Name or Path	73
6.	Empty Password in Configuration File	258
7.	Insufficient verification of data Authenticity	345
8.	Improper output Neutralization for Logs	117
9.	Generation of error messages Containing sensitive information	209
10.	Declaration of Catch for Generic Exception	396

1. VULNERABILITY NAME: Improper Limitation of a pathname to a restricted directory

CWE: 22

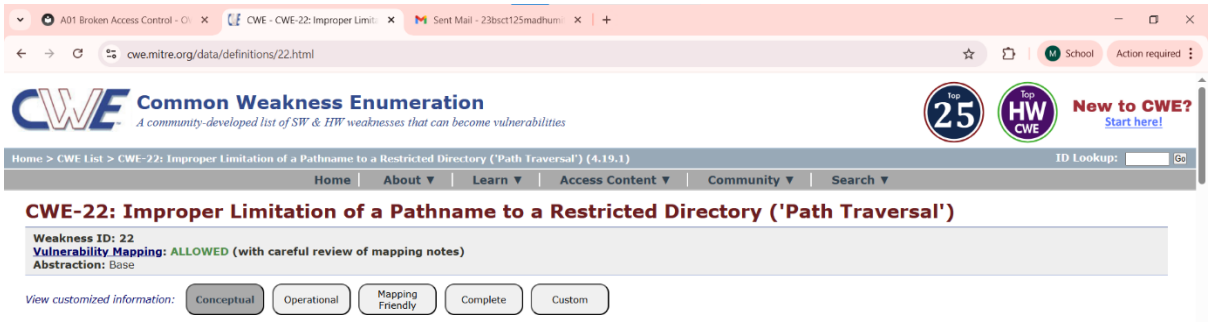
Description:

CWE-22 Improper Limitation of a Pathname to a Restricted Directory**,** commonly called Path Traversal, is a security vulnerability where an application fails to properly restrict user-supplied file paths, allowing attackers to access files or directories outside the intended directory. By manipulating input with sequences like ../, an attacker can traverse the file system and potentially read sensitive files (such as configuration files, system credentials, or source code) or access restricted resources on the server. This vulnerability occurs when applications do not properly validate, sanitize, or restrict file path inputs before using them in file system operations.

Business impact:

Path Traversal vulnerabilities allow attackers to access files and directories outside the intend ed application directory by manipulating file path inputs. From a business perspective, this vu lnerability can cause significant damage. Attackers may gain unauthorized access to sensitive files such as configuration files, credentials, customer data, or internal documents. This can l ead to data breaches, exposing confidential information and violating privacy regulations.Suc h incidents often result in financial losses due to regulatory fines, legal actions, incident respo nse costs, and potential compensation to affected customers. In addition, exploitation of this v ulnerability can disrupt normal operations if critical system files are modified or deleted, lead ing to service downtime and reduced productivity.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/22.html



2. VULNERABILITY NAME: Unimplemented or Unsupported Feature in UI

CWE: 447

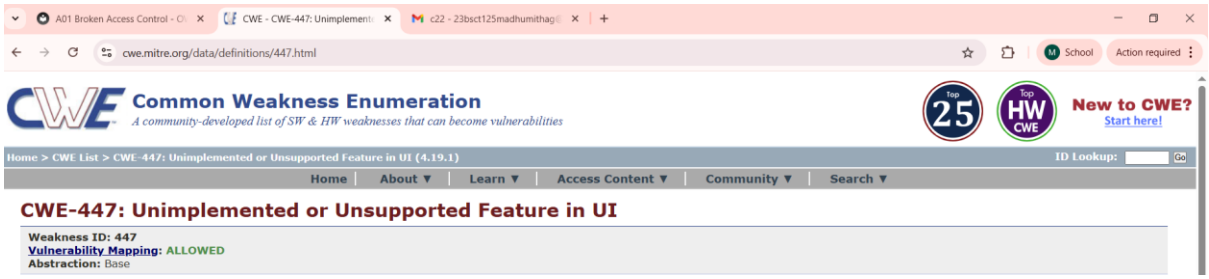
Description:

Use of Obsolete Function refers to a security weakness that occurs when a program uses out dated or deprecated functions that are no longer considered safe or recommended. These obsolete functions may contain known vulnerabilities, lack modern security protections, or behave in ways that can lead to security risks such as buffer overflows, improper memory handling, or data exposure.

Business Impact:

When a user interface exposes features that are not actually implemented or supported, it can create significant business risks. First, it leads to loss of user trust and credibility, as customers expect advertised features to function properly. When they encounter non-working options, they may perceive the product as unreliable or poorly maintained. Second, it can result in increased support and maintenance costs. Users often report such issues to customer support, increasing workload and operational expenses. Development teams may also need emergency fixes or UI redesigns to correct the misleading functionality.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/447.html



3. VULNERABILITY NAME: Weak Encoding for Password

CWE: 261

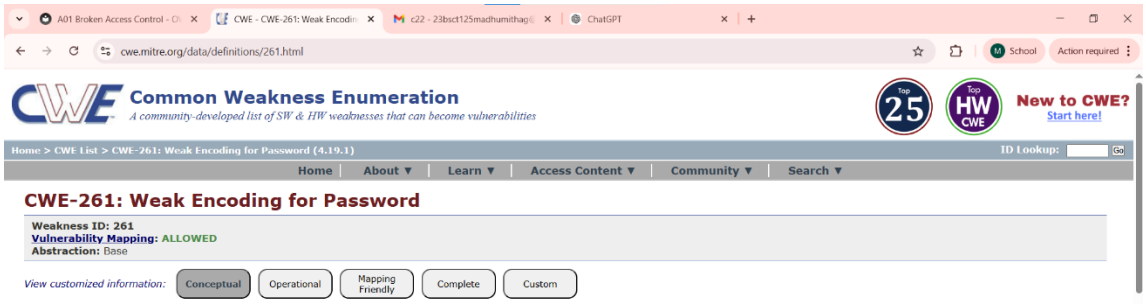
Description:

Weak Encoding for Password is a security weakness that occurs when an application stores or transmits passwords using simple or reversible encoding methods instead of strong cryptographic hashing. Encoding techniques such as Base64 or other basic transformations can easily be decoded by attackers, allowing them to recover the original passwords.

Business impact:

CWE-261 Weak Encoding for Password refers to storing or transmitting passwords using weak or reversible encoding methods (such as Base64) instead of strong cryptographic hashing. This vulnerability can have significant business consequences. If attackers gain access to encoded passwords, they can easily decode them and obtain valid user credentials. This may lead to unauthorized system access, data breaches, and account takeovers. For organizations, such incidents can result in financial losses due to fraud, operational disruption, and incident response costs. Additionally, compromised credentials may allow attackers to move laterally within internal systems, exposing sensitive corporate or customer data.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/261.html



4. VULNERABILITY NAME: Improper Input Validation

CWE: 20

Description:

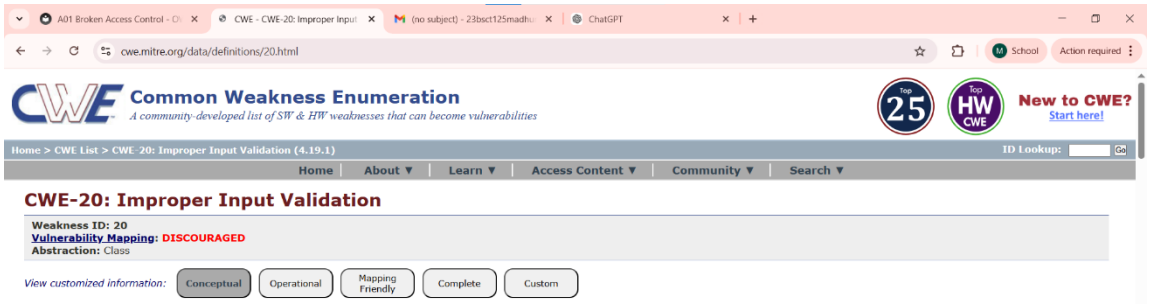
Improper Input Validation is a security vulnerability that occurs when a program fails to properly check or validate input provided by users or external sources. Without proper validation, attackers may send malicious or unexpected data that can cause the system to behave incorrectly, leading to issues such as injection attacks, system crashes, or unauthorized access.

Business impact:

CWE-20 Improper Input Validation occurs when an application fails to properly validate user inputs before processing them. This weakness can allow attackers to submit malicious or unexpected data that the system is not designed to handle. From a business perspective, this vulnerability can lead to serious security and operational risks. Attackers may exploit improper input validation to perform attacks such as injection, unauthorized data access, or system manipulation. As a result, sensitive information like customer records, financial data, or internal business details may be exposed or altered.The financial impact can be significant. Organizations may incur costs related to incident response, system recovery, legal actions,

and regulatory penalties if sensitive data is compromised. In industries that must comply with data protection regulations, failure to properly validate inputs may be considered negligence, resulting in compliance violations and fines.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/20.html



5. VULNERABILITY NAME: External Control of File Name or Path

CWE: 73

Description:

External Control of File Name or Path is a security vulnerability that occurs when an application allows external input, such as user-supplied data, to determine the file name or file path used in file operations. If this input is not properly validated or restricted, attackers may manipulate the path to access unauthorized files, overwrite important system files, or execute malicious actions (for example through path traversal attacks).

Business impact:

CWE-73 External Control of File Name or Path occurs when an application allows external users to control or influence file names or file paths without proper validation or restriction. This vulnerability can allow attackers to manipulate file operations, potentially accessing or modifying files that should not be exposed. From a business perspective, this weakness can lead to serious security, financial, and operational consequences.

Attackers may exploit this issue to perform path traversal attacks, enabling them to read sensitive files such as configuration files, system credentials, or internal documents. Exposure of such information can result in data breaches involving confidential customer data, intellectual property, or business secrets.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/73.html

6. VULNERABILITY NAME: Empty Password in Configuration File

CWE: 258

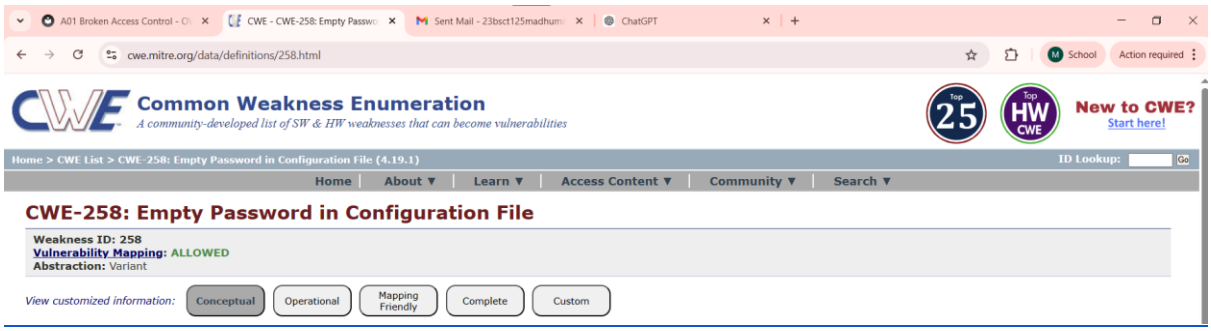
Description:

Empty Password in Configuration File is a security vulnerability that occurs when a configuration file contains an account or service with an empty password. This means the system allows authentication without requiring any password, making it extremely easy for attackers to gain unauthorized access. If an attacker discovers such a configuration, they can log in or access sensitive services without any authentication barrier. To prevent this issue, all accounts and services should be configured with strong, non-empty passwords and secure authentication mechanisms.

Business Impact:

CWE-258 Empty Password in Configuration File occurs when a configuration file contains an account or service with a blank or empty password. This security weakness significantly increases the risk of unauthorized access because attackers can authenticate to systems, databases, or services without needing valid credentials. From a business perspective, this vulnerability can lead to serious security and operational risks.If exploited, attackers may gain direct access to sensitive systems, allowing them to view, modify, or delete critical business data.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/258.html



7. VULNERABILITY NAME: Insufficient Verification of Data Authenticity

CWE: 345

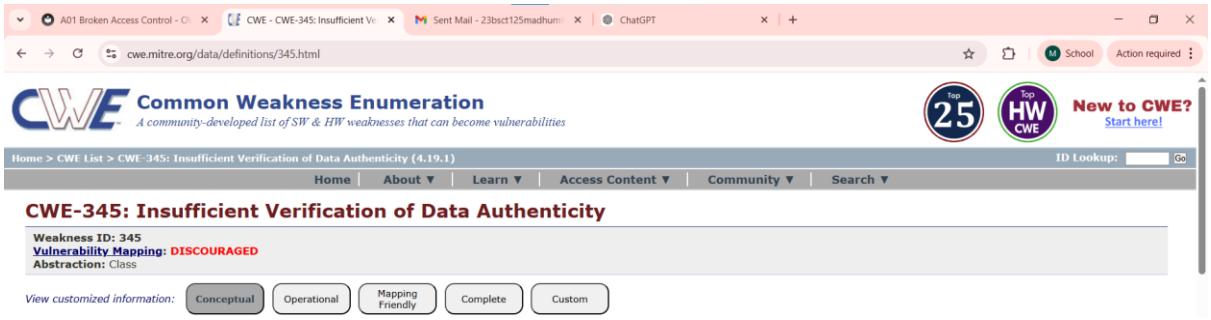
Description:

Insufficient Verification of Data Authenticity is a security vulnerability that occurs when a system does not properly verify whether received data is genuine and comes from a trusted source. Without adequate authenticity checks, attackers may modify, forge, or inject malicious data into the system, potentially leading to unauthorized actions, incorrect processing, or security breaches. This weakness often arises when applications fail to use mechanisms such as digital signatures, certificates, or secure cryptographic verification. Implementing strong authentication and validation methods helps ensure that the data being processed is trustworthy and has not been tampered with.

Business impact:

CWE-345 Insufficient Verification of Data Authenticity occurs when a system fails to properly verify whether data originates from a trusted source or has been tampered with during transmission or processing. This weakness can allow attackers to inject malicious or altered data into an application, leading to unauthorized actions or incorrect system behavior. From a business perspective, exploitation of this vulnerability can compromise the integrity of critical business data.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/345.html



8. VULNERABILITY NAME: Improper Output Neutralization for Logs

CWE: 117

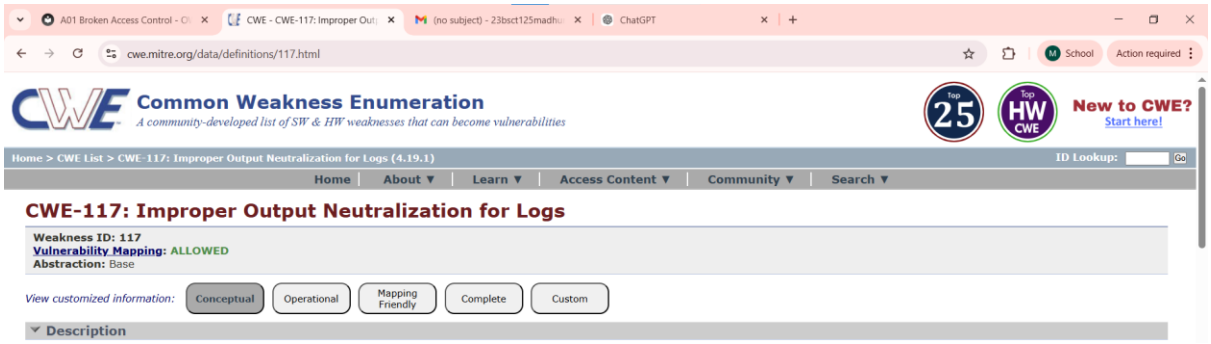
Description:

Improper Output Neutralization for Logs is a security vulnerability that occurs when an application writes untrusted input directly into log files without properly sanitizing or neutralizing it. Attackers can exploit this weakness by inserting malicious characters or log entries that may alter the structure of the logs, hide malicious activities, or mislead administrators during log analysis. This can compromise the reliability and integrity of log records. Properly validating and neutralizing user input before writing it to logs helps maintain accurate and secure logging.

Business Impact:

CWE-117 Improper Output Neutralization for Logs occurs when an application fails to properly sanitize or neutralize user-controlled input before writing it to log files. This vulnerability allows attackers to inject malicious content into logs, potentially altering log records or inserting fake log entries. From a business perspective, this can significantly affect the integrity and reliability of logging systems. Attackers may manipulate logs to hide malicious activities, mislead security teams, or create false records that complicate incident investigations.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/117.html



9. Vulnerability name: Generation of Error Message Containing Sensitive Information

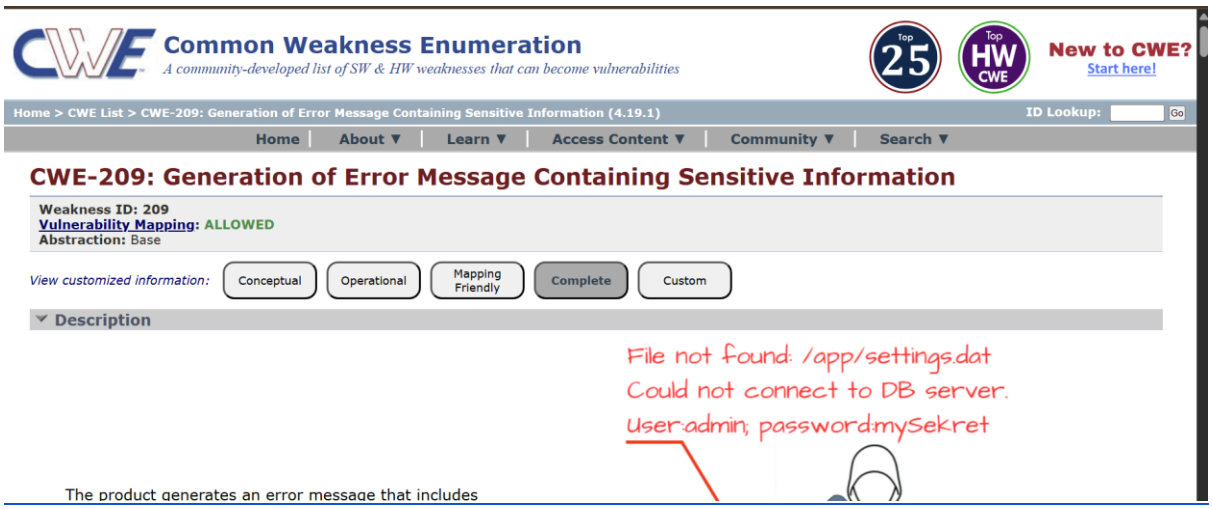
CWE: 209

Description:
Generation of Error Message Containing Sensitive Information is a security vulnerability that occurs when an application reveals sensitive information in its error messages. These messages may include details such as system paths, database queries, configuration settings, or internal application logic. Attackers can use this information to better understand the system and exploit other vulnerabilities. To prevent this issue, applications should display generic error messages to users while logging detailed error information securely for administrators.

Business Impact:

CWE-209 Generation of Error Message Containing Sensitive Information occurs when an application displays detailed error messages that reveal sensitive system information to users. These messages may expose internal system paths, database queries, configuration details, or software components. From a business perspective, this vulnerability can significantly increase the risk of targeted cyberattacks.Attackers can use the exposed information to better understand the system's architecture and identify additional vulnerabilities to exploit. This may lead to unauthorized access, data breaches, or further attacks such as injection or system compromise.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/209.html



10. VULNERABILITY NAME: Declaration of Catch for Generic Exception

CWE: 396

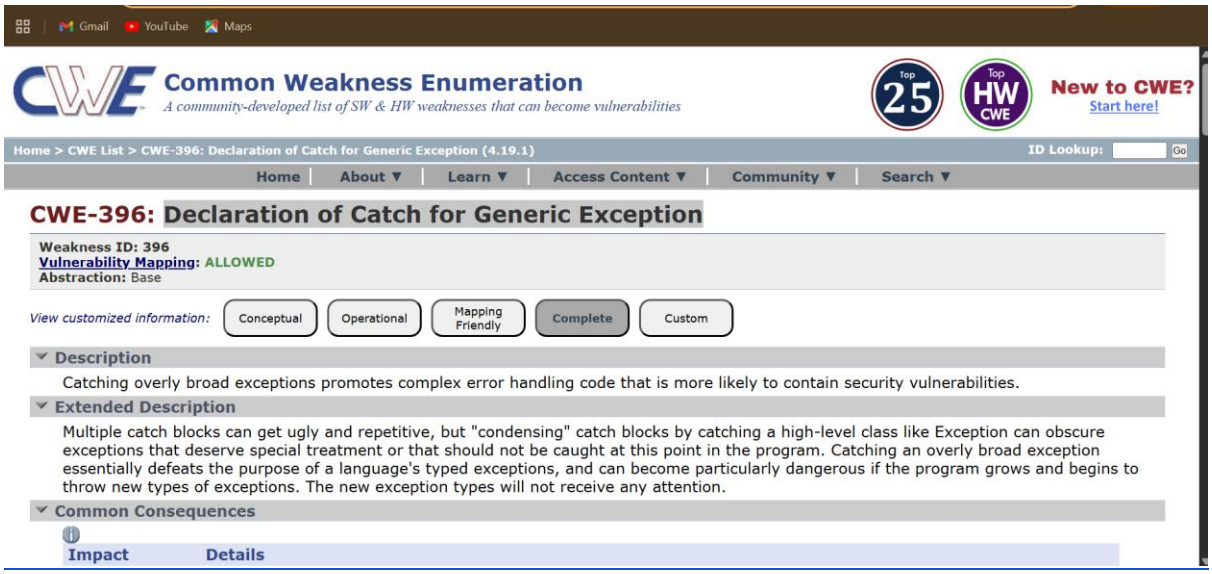
Description:

The Declaration of Catch for Generic Exception vulnerability occurs when an application catches a broad or generic exception (such as Exception or Throwable) instead of handling specific exception types. This practice prevents the application from distinguishing between different error conditions and may hide the real cause of failures. As a result, important exceptions related to system errors, security issues, or application logic may be improperly handled or ignored, making debugging and proper error management difficult. Secure coding guidelines from organizations such as OWASP discourage catching generic exceptions because it reduces code reliability and weakens proper error handling practices.

Business Impact:

If generic exceptions are used, critical errors or security-related issues may be suppressed without proper handling or logging, which can lead to application instability, undetected security problems, and difficulty in troubleshooting incidents. This can result in system downtime, data integrity issues, and increased operational costs due to longer debugging and recovery times. In some cases, attackers may exploit hidden failures to bypass controls or disrupt services, potentially affecting business operations, customer trust, and compliance with secure development standards recommended by organizations like OWASP.

Vulnerability Path: https://cwe.mitre.org/data/definitions/396.html



STAGE – 2

TITLE: Enforce least-privilege access through identity-aware, application-specific access policies using Zscaler Private Access (ZPA).

S. No	Vulnerability Name	Severity	Plugins
1.	Nessus SYN scanner	INFO	11219
2.	Hypertext transfer protocol	INFO	24260
3.	HTTP Server type version	INFO	10107
4.	Web Server robots.txt information disclosure	INFO	10302
5.	Service Detection	INFO	22964

1. VULNERABILITY NAME: NESSUS SYN SCANNER
SEVERITY: INFO
PLUGIN: 11219

Description:

The *Nessus SYN Scanner* finding indicates that a system or network device has detected a **TCP SYN scan**, which is a technique used to identify open ports on a target host. In a SYN scan, the scanner sends TCP SYN packets to various ports and analyzes the responses to determine whether the ports are open, closed, or filtered without completing the full TCP handshake. This method is commonly used by vulnerability scanning tools such as Nessus developed by Tenable to discover exposed services during security assessments. While SYN scanning is legitimate in authorized vulnerability assessments, its detection may indicate that a system is being actively scanned for potential entry points.

Business Impact:

If SYN scanning activity is performed by unauthorized sources, it may indicate reconnaissance by attackers attempting to identify open ports and vulnerable services within the organization's network. This information can help attackers plan further exploitation attempts, potentially leading to unauthorized access, service disruption, or data breaches. Continuous scanning may also increase network noise and security alerts, making it harder to distinguish real attacks from normal traffic and increasing the workload for security teams.

Solution:

Organizations should ensure that only authorized vulnerability scanners are allowed to perform scans within the network. Implement firewall and intrusion detection/prevention systems to monitor and restrict unauthorized port scanning activities. Network administrators should review the source of the SYN scan, verify whether it originates from an approved security tool such as Nessus, and block or investigate any suspicious or unknown sources. Additionally, limiting exposed services and applying proper network segmentation can reduce the attack surface and minimize the effectiveness of reconnaissance attempts.

2. VULNERABILITY NAME: HYPERTEXT TRANSFER PROTOCOL
SEVERITY: INFO
PLUGIN: 24260

Description:

The **Hypertext Transfer Protocol (HTTP)** vulnerability refers to the use of the unsecured HTTP protocol for transmitting data between a client and a web server. HTTP sends data in **plain text**, meaning that information such as login credentials, session tokens, and other sensitive data can be intercepted or modified by attackers during transmission. Because the communication is not encrypted, it is vulnerable to attacks such as eavesdropping, session hijacking, and man-in-the-middle attacks. Security best practices from organizations such as OWASP recommend using encrypted communication protocols to protect sensitive information transmitted over networks.

Business Impact:

If a web application uses HTTP instead of secure communication, attackers may intercept sensitive data transmitted between users and the server. This could lead to unauthorized access to user accounts, exposure of confidential business information, or manipulation of transmitted data. Such incidents can result in data breaches, loss of customer trust, reputational damage, and potential regulatory or compliance issues for the organization.

Solution:

To mitigate this vulnerability, organizations should enforce the use of **HTTPS** instead of HTTP for all web communications. Implement an SSL/TLS certificate and configure the web server to automatically redirect all HTTP requests to HTTPS. Additionally, enable strong encryption protocols and disable insecure versions of SSL/TLS to ensure secure

communication. Following secure development and configuration practices recommended by organizations like OWASP will help protect sensitive data during transmission.

3. VULNERABILITY NAME: HTTP SERVER TYPE VERSION
SEVERITY: INFO
PLUGIN: 10107

Description:

The **HTTP Server Type and Version Disclosure** vulnerability occurs when a web server reveals detailed information about the server software and its version in HTTP response headers or error pages. For example, the server may expose headers such as Server: Apache/2.4.49 or Server: nginx/1.18.0. This information disclosure allows attackers to identify the exact server software and version being used. If the disclosed version has known vulnerabilities, attackers can use publicly available exploits to target the system. Security guidance from organizations such as OWASP recommends minimizing server information disclosure to reduce the risk of targeted attacks.

Business Impact:

Exposing the HTTP server type and version can assist attackers in reconnaissance activities by providing information about the technologies used in the environment. This makes it easier for attackers to identify known vulnerabilities associated with that specific server version and launch targeted attacks. Successful exploitation could lead to unauthorized access, service disruption, data compromise, or further attacks on internal systems, which may impact business operations and damage the organization's reputation.

Solution:

To mitigate this vulnerability, configure the web server to hide or suppress server version information in HTTP response headers and error messages. For example, modify server configuration settings to disable or limit the Server and X-Powered-By headers. Additionally, keep web server software such as Apache HTTP Server or Nginx updated with the latest security patches and follow secure configuration guidelines recommended by OWASP. This reduces the risk of attackers identifying and exploiting known vulnerabilities.

4. VULNERABILITY NAME: WEB SERVER ROBTS.TXT INFORMATION DISCOLURE
SEVERITY: INFO
PLUGIN: 10302

Description:

The **Web Server robots.txt Information Disclosure** vulnerability occurs when the `robots.txt` file on a web server reveals sensitive or restricted directories that should not be indexed by search engines. The `robots.txt` file is used to instruct search engine crawlers

about which parts of a website should not be crawled or indexed. However, because this file is publicly accessible, attackers can view it and identify hidden or sensitive paths such as administrative panels, backup folders, or internal resources. Security organizations such as OWASP consider this an information disclosure issue because it unintentionally exposes the structure of the web application.

Business Impact:

If sensitive directories or files are listed in the `robots.txt` file, attackers can use this information to locate restricted areas of the application, such as login portals, configuration files, or backup directories. This may assist attackers in conducting further reconnaissance or launching targeted attacks against these resources. In some cases, this could lead to unauthorized access, exposure of confidential data, or exploitation of vulnerable components, which can impact business operations and compromise the security of the application.

Solution:

To mitigate this vulnerability, avoid listing sensitive or confidential directories in the `robots.txt` file. Instead of relying on `robots.txt` to restrict access, implement proper access control mechanisms such as authentication and authorization to protect sensitive resources. Additionally, review the web application structure and ensure that administrative or internal directories are not publicly accessible. Following secure configuration practices recommended by organizations such as OWASP can help reduce the risk of information disclosure.

5. VULNERABILITY NAME: SERVICE DETECTION
SEVERITY: INFO
PLUGIN: 22964

Description:

The **Service Detection** vulnerability indicates that a scanning tool has successfully identified services running on open ports of a host. During this process, the scanner interacts with the target system to determine the type of service (such as web server, database, or mail server) and sometimes the version of the software running on those ports. Tools such as Nmap and vulnerability scanners like Nessus commonly perform service detection during security assessments. While this activity itself is not a direct vulnerability, it reveals information about the services available on the system, which can assist attackers in identifying potential targets.

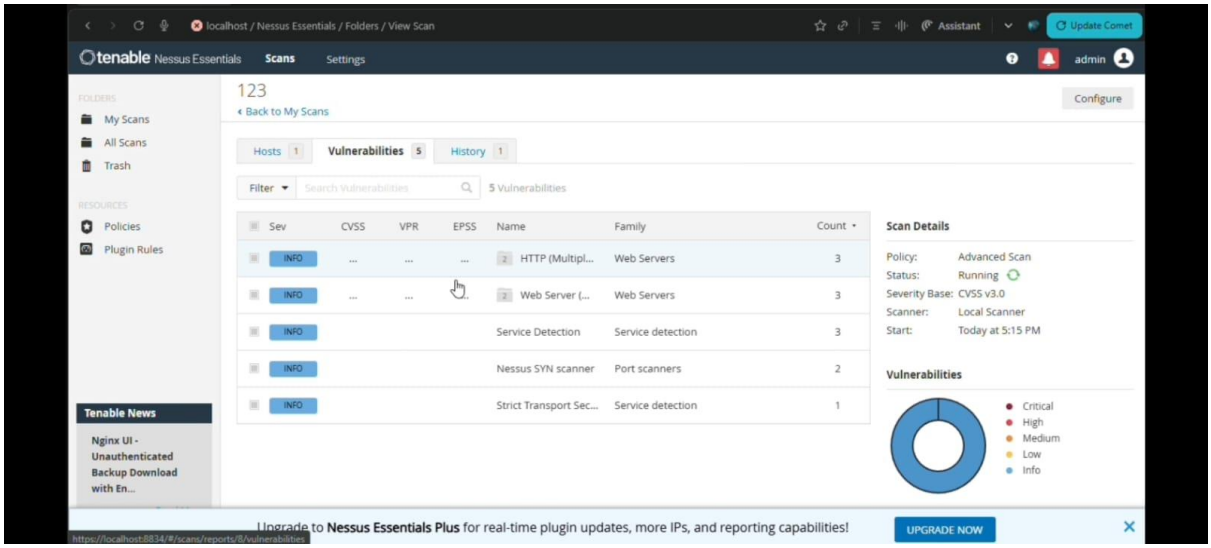
Business Impact:

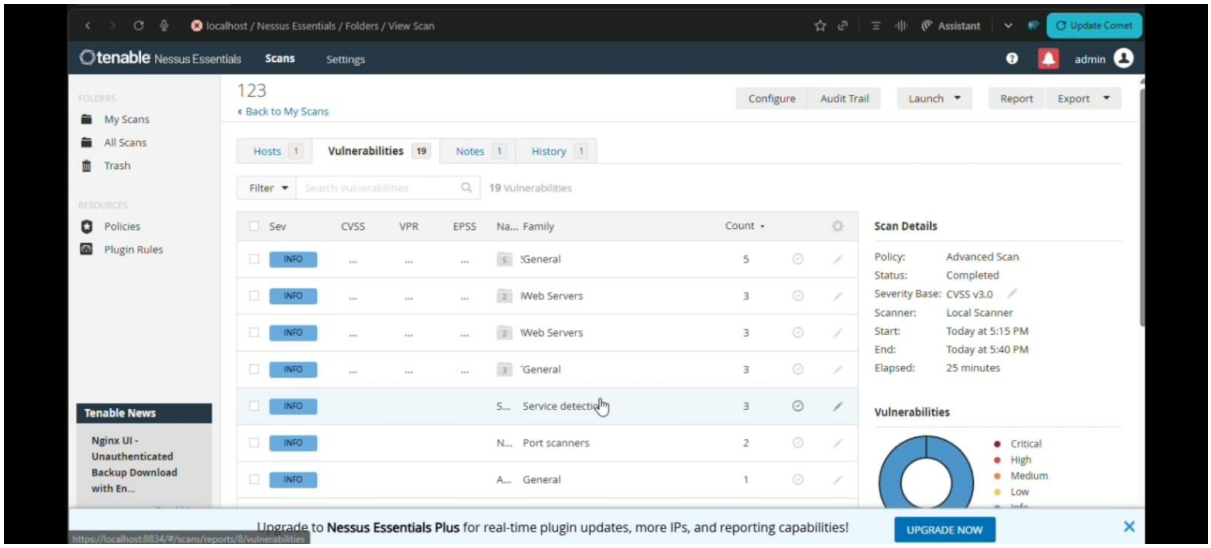
If attackers are able to detect and identify running services on a system, they may use this information to perform further reconnaissance and search for known vulnerabilities associated with those services. This could enable targeted exploitation attempts, unauthorized access, or disruption of services. In environments where sensitive systems are exposed, service detection may increase the risk of attacks against critical infrastructure, potentially affecting system availability, data confidentiality, and overall business operations.

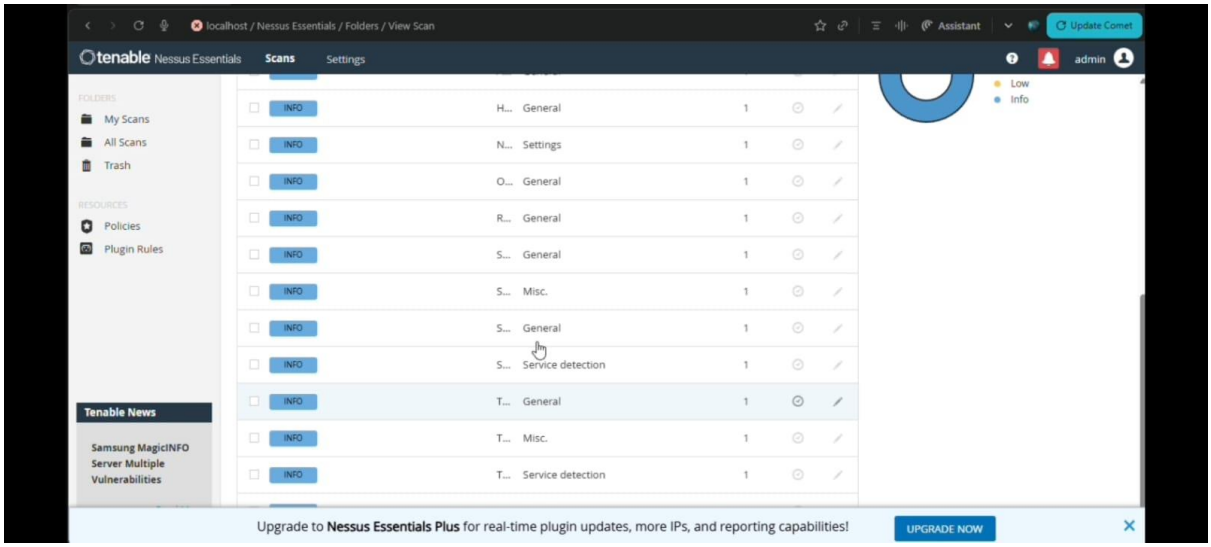
Solution:

To mitigate risks associated with service detection, organizations should minimize the exposure of unnecessary services by disabling unused ports and services on servers and network devices. Implement firewall rules and network segmentation to restrict access to critical services only from trusted sources. Additionally, regularly update and patch services to address known vulnerabilities and follow security best practices recommended by organizations such as OWASP. Monitoring network traffic and intrusion detection systems can also help identify and respond to unauthorized scanning activities.

NESSUSS SCAN REPORT:






localhost / Nessus Essentials / Folders / View Scan
Assistant
Update Comet
tenable Nessus Essentials
Scans
Settings
admin
FOLDERS
My Scans
All Scans
Trash
RESOURCES
Policies
Plugin Rules
Tenable News
Samsung MagicINFO Server Multiple Vulnerabilities
INFO H... General 1
INFO N... Settings 1
INFO O... General 1
INFO R... General 1
INFO S... General 1
INFO S... Misc. 1
INFO S... General 1
INFO S... Service detection 1
INFO T... General 1
INFO T... Misc. 1
INFO T... Service detection 1
Low
Info
Upgrade to Nessus Essentials Plus for real-time plugin updates, more IPs, and reporting capabilities!
UPGRADE NOW

STAGE – 3

TITLE: Enforce least-privilege access through identity-aware, application-specific access policies using Zscaler Private Access (ZPA).

OVERVIEW: ENFORCE LEAST-PRIVILEGE ACCESS WITH ZSCALER PRIVATE ACCESS (ZPA)

Zscaler Private Access (ZPA) is a cloud-based Zero Trust Network Access (ZTNA) solution from Zscaler that enables organizations to enforce **least-privilege access** by granting users secure, identity-based access only to specific internal applications rather than providing broad network access.

In traditional VPN architectures, users often receive **network-level access** once connected, which can expose multiple internal systems and increase the risk of lateral movement if an account is compromised. ZPA replaces this model with a **Zero Trust approach**, where access is granted based on verified identity, device posture, and contextual policies. Instead of connecting users to the network, ZPA connects them **directly to the specific application they are authorized to use**.

With ZPA, administrators create **application-specific access policies** that determine who can access a particular application based on factors such as user identity, role, device status, and location. Integration with identity providers (such as SSO or directory services) allows ZPA to enforce **identity-aware policies**, ensuring that only authenticated and authorized users can reach internal resources. Because applications are not directly exposed to the internet and are only accessible through the ZPA broker, the attack surface is significantly reduced.

This approach supports the Zero Trust Architecture security model, where no user or device is trusted by default and continuous verification is required. By implementing least-privilege, identity-based access with ZPA, organizations can improve security, reduce the risk of unauthorized access or lateral movement, and provide secure remote access to internal applications without relying on traditional VPN solutions.

IDENTITY-AWARE ACCESS:

Zscaler Private Access (ZPA) enables **identity-aware access** by verifying the user's identity before granting access to internal applications. Instead of allowing users to connect to the entire corporate network, ZPA evaluates the user's identity through integration with identity providers such as Microsoft Entra ID, Okta, or Active Directory. Access policies are then applied based on attributes such as user role, group membership, device posture, and contextual factors like location or authentication method.

With this approach, users are granted access **only to the specific applications they are authorized to use**, enforcing the principle of least privilege. This identity-centric model

aligns with the concepts of Zero Trust Architecture, where trust is continuously verified and access is strictly controlled to minimize the risk of unauthorized access and lateral movement within the organization's network.

APPLICATION-SPECIFIC ACCESS POLICIES:

Zscaler Private Access (ZPA) enforces **application-specific access policies** by granting users access only to the particular internal applications they are authorized to use rather than providing full network access. Administrators define policies that map specific users or user groups to individual applications based on attributes such as identity, role, department, device posture, and location.

Through integration with identity providers like Microsoft Entra ID, Okta, or Active Directory, ZPA verifies user identity and applies predefined access rules. When a user attempts to access an application, ZPA checks the configured policies and establishes a secure, direct connection only if the user meets the defined criteria. This prevents users from discovering or accessing other internal services and significantly reduces the attack surface.

By limiting access strictly to required applications, this policy framework supports the principles of Zero Trust Architecture and ensures that organizations maintain strong security controls while enabling secure remote access to internal resources.

IMPLEMENTATION METHODOLOGY

To enforce least-privilege access using **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)**, organizations should follow a structured implementation approach that integrates identity verification, application segmentation, and policy-based access control.

- **Assess Applications and Access Requirements:** Begin by identifying all internal applications that require secure access. Classify these applications based on sensitivity, user groups, and business requirements to determine who should have access and under what conditions.
- **Integrate Identity Provider (IdP):** Configure ZPA to integrate with an enterprise identity provider such as Microsoft Entra ID, Okta, or Active Directory. This integration enables authentication and ensures that user identity, group membership, and role information can be used to enforce access policies.
- **Deploy ZPA Components:** Install the ZPA App Connector within the internal network or cloud environment where the applications are hosted. The App Connector establishes secure outbound connections to the ZPA cloud, ensuring that internal applications remain hidden from direct internet exposure.
- **Define Application Segments:** Create application segments within ZPA that represent the internal services or applications users need to access. Each segment should correspond to a specific application or group of related services.
- **Configure Identity-Aware Access Policies:** Develop access policies based on user identity, department, device posture, and contextual factors such as location or

authentication method. These policies should follow the **least-privilege principle**, ensuring users can access only the applications required for their roles.

- **Enforce Application-Specific Access:** Map user groups to the appropriate application segments so that users receive access only to authorized applications instead of the entire network. This approach aligns with the principles of Zero Trust Architecture.
- **Test and Validate Access Controls:** Conduct testing to verify that users can access only the applications they are permitted to use and that unauthorized access attempts are blocked. Validate functionality across different user roles and device types.
- **Monitor and Continuously Improve:** Use ZPA monitoring and logging capabilities to track access events, detect anomalies, and refine policies. Regularly review access permissions to ensure they remain aligned with business needs and security requirements.

TOOLS AND TECHNOLOGIES

Implementing least-privilege access through identity-aware, application-specific policies using **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)** requires several supporting tools and technologies that enable authentication, policy enforcement, secure connectivity, and monitoring.

1. Zero Trust Network Access Platform:

The core technology used is **Zscaler Private Access**, which provides secure, application-level access to internal resources without exposing the corporate network. It acts as a broker that connects authenticated users directly to authorized applications.

2. Identity and Access Management (IAM) Systems:

Identity-aware access requires integration with identity providers such as **Microsoft Entra ID**, **Okta**, and **Active Directory**. These systems authenticate users and provide identity attributes like roles and group memberships that are used to enforce access policies.

3. Single Sign-On (SSO) and Authentication Protocols:

Authentication is typically implemented using protocols such as **SAML (Security Assertion Markup Language)** and **OpenID Connect**, which allow seamless and secure identity verification between the identity provider and ZPA.

4. ZPA App Connectors:

App Connectors are lightweight virtual appliances deployed inside the internal network or cloud environment. They establish secure outbound connections to the ZPA cloud and enable access to internal applications without exposing them to the internet.

5. Endpoint Security and Device Posture Tools:

Endpoint protection and device management tools can be integrated to verify device compliance before granting access. These tools ensure that only trusted and secure devices can connect to internal applications.

6. Monitoring and Logging Platforms:

Security monitoring tools such as **Splunk** or **IBM QRadar** can be integrated to collect logs, monitor access events, and detect suspicious activities related to application access.

INTEGRATION WITH IDENTITY PROVIDERS

Integration with Identity Providers (IdPs) is a key component in implementing identity-aware access control using **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)**. It allows organizations to authenticate users and apply access policies based on verified identity attributes such as user roles, group memberships, and authentication status.

ZPA integrates with enterprise identity platforms such as **Microsoft Entra ID**, **Okta**, and **Active Directory** to enable centralized authentication and authorization. When a user attempts to access an internal application, the request is redirected to the configured identity provider for authentication. After successful verification, the identity provider sends authentication information to ZPA using secure protocols such as **SAML (Security Assertion Markup Language)** or **OpenID Connect**.

Once the user's identity is verified, ZPA evaluates predefined access policies and determines whether the user is authorized to access the requested application. These policies can be based on user identity, department, device posture, location, and other contextual factors. By integrating with identity providers, organizations can enforce the **least-privilege principle** and ensure that users are granted access only to the applications required for their roles, supporting a secure Zero Trust Architecture model.

DEVICE POSTURE CHECKING

Device Posture Checking is a security mechanism used in **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)** to verify the security status of a user's device before allowing access to internal applications. In a Zero Trust environment, access decisions are not based only on user identity but also on whether the device being used meets the organization's security requirements.

ZPA integrates with endpoint management and security platforms such as **Microsoft Intune**, **CrowdStrike Falcon**, or other endpoint protection tools to assess device compliance. The system checks various security attributes such as operating system version, presence of endpoint protection software, device encryption status, patch levels, and whether the device is managed by the organization.

If the device meets the defined security posture requirements, ZPA allows the user to securely connect to authorized applications. If the device does not meet the required security standards, access may be denied or restricted until the device becomes compliant. This ensures that only trusted and secure devices can access internal resources, supporting the

principles of **Zero Trust Architecture** and helping organizations reduce the risk of compromised or unmanaged devices accessing sensitive applications.

MICRO-TUNNELING AND APPLICATION VISIBILITY

Micro-tunneling is a core capability of **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)** that enables secure, application-level connectivity between a user and a specific internal application. Instead of creating a full network tunnel like traditional VPNs, ZPA establishes a **temporary, encrypted micro-tunnel** only when a user requests access to an authorized application. This tunnel is created dynamically between the user's device and the application through the ZPA cloud, ensuring that the user is connected only to the required service and not the entire corporate network. This approach prevents lateral movement and reduces the attack surface.

Application visibility refers to the ability of administrators to monitor and analyze how users interact with internal applications accessed through ZPA. The platform provides detailed insights into user access patterns, application usage, connection status, and policy enforcement events. These visibility features allow security teams to track who accessed which applications, from which device, and under what conditions. The collected data can also be integrated with security monitoring tools to support auditing, threat detection, and compliance requirements.

THREAT INTELLIGENCE INTEGRATION

Threat Intelligence Integration enhances the security capabilities of **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)** by incorporating real-time threat intelligence to identify and block malicious activities before they reach internal applications. ZPA leverages threat intelligence from the **Zscaler ThreatLabz** research team, which continuously analyzes global internet traffic to detect emerging cyber threats, malicious domains, and suspicious behaviors.

Through this integration, ZPA can automatically evaluate incoming connections and user activity against known threat indicators such as malicious IP addresses, compromised domains, and abnormal access patterns. If a threat is detected, the platform can block or restrict access to the application, preventing potential attacks from reaching internal resources.

Additionally, threat intelligence data can be integrated with external security monitoring platforms such as **Splunk** or **IBM QRadar** for centralized analysis and incident response. By combining identity-aware access control with continuous threat intelligence monitoring, organizations can strengthen their Zero Trust Architecture model and proactively defend against evolving cyber threats.

UNDERSTANDING ZPA: KEY TAKEAWAYS

Zscaler Private Access (ZPA) is a cloud-delivered Zero Trust Network Access (ZTNA) solution developed by Zscaler that provides secure access to internal applications without exposing the corporate network to the internet. It replaces traditional VPN-based access by connecting authenticated users directly to specific applications rather than granting broad network connectivity.

Key Takeaways:

- **Zero Trust Security Model:** ZPA follows the principles of Zero Trust Architecture, where no user or device is trusted by default. Access is granted only after verifying identity, device posture, and security policies.
- **Application-Level Access:** Users are connected only to the specific applications they are authorized to access, preventing unnecessary exposure of the internal network.
- **Least-Privilege Enforcement:** ZPA ensures that users receive only the minimum level of access required for their roles, reducing the risk of unauthorized access and lateral movement within the network.
- **Identity-Aware Access Control:** Integration with identity providers such as Microsoft Entra ID, Okta, and Active Directory allows organizations to enforce access policies based on user identity and role.
- **Secure Micro-Tunneling:** ZPA creates secure, encrypted micro-tunnels between users and applications only when access is requested, ensuring that internal applications remain hidden from direct internet exposure.
- **Enhanced Visibility and Monitoring:** Administrators gain detailed visibility into user access patterns, application usage, and security events, enabling better monitoring, auditing, and threat detection.

CONCLUSION

Stage 1: Web application security assessment is a vital step in ensuring that modern web-based systems remain secure, reliable, and efficient. Through systematic testing and analysis, potential vulnerabilities in the application's functionality, configuration, and security controls can be identified and addressed before they are exploited by attackers. This stage focuses on evaluating the application environment, identifying weaknesses, and understanding the potential risks associated with them. By conducting thorough assessments, organizations can strengthen the overall quality and resilience of their web applications, ensuring that users experience secure and uninterrupted services while minimizing the risk of data breaches and system compromise.

Stage 2: The vulnerability assessment performed using **Nessus** provides valuable insights into the security posture of the target system. The scan results highlight various vulnerabilities and configuration issues that could potentially expose the system to cyber threats. These findings are categorized based on severity levels, enabling security teams to prioritize remediation efforts effectively. The report also provides practical recommendations such as applying security patches, improving system configurations, and implementing stronger security controls. By aligning remediation strategies with industry best practices recommended by **OWASP**, organizations can significantly reduce their exposure to threats. Continuous monitoring, regular vulnerability scanning, and timely updates are essential to maintaining a strong and proactive security posture.

Stage 3: The implementation of **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)** represents a modern approach to securing access to internal applications by adopting the principles of **Zero Trust Architecture**. By enforcing identity-aware, application-specific access policies and least-privilege principles, the organization can ensure that users gain access only to the resources necessary for their roles. This approach minimizes the risk of unauthorized access and

prevents lateral movement within the network. Additionally, ZPA improves visibility into user activity and application access while eliminating the need for traditional VPN-based connectivity. Overall, this stage establishes a secure, scalable, and future-ready framework that strengthens the organization's ability to protect its critical resources while supporting modern remote and distributed work environments.

FUTURE SCOPE

Stage 1: The future scope of web application security testing lies in adopting more advanced and automated security assessment techniques to address evolving cyber threats. Organizations can integrate automated security testing into their development pipelines through DevSecOps practices, ensuring vulnerabilities are detected and resolved during the early stages of development. The use of artificial intelligence and machine learning can further enhance vulnerability detection and threat analysis. Additionally, implementing regular penetration testing, continuous security monitoring, and secure coding practices recommended by OWASP will help organizations strengthen the security posture of their web applications and maintain resilience against emerging threats.

Stage 2: In the future, vulnerability management can be enhanced by implementing continuous vulnerability scanning and automated remediation processes using advanced security tools such as **Nessus**. Organizations can integrate vulnerability scanning with Security Information and Event Management (SIEM) systems and threat intelligence platforms to improve real-time threat detection and response. Expanding the scope of security assessments to include cloud infrastructure, APIs, and containerized environments will also become increasingly important as organizations adopt modern technologies. Regular security audits, compliance checks, and proactive patch management will ensure that systems remain protected against newly discovered vulnerabilities.

Stage 3: The future scope of secure access management involves expanding the implementation of **Zscaler Private Access (ZPA)** and other Zero Trust technologies across the entire enterprise environment. Organizations can further enhance access security by integrating advanced device posture checks, behavioral analytics, and adaptive access controls. As remote and hybrid work models continue to grow, adopting a comprehensive Zero Trust Architecture will help ensure secure and seamless access to applications regardless of user location or device. Future improvements may also include deeper integration with identity management platforms, cloud security services, and threat intelligence systems to provide stronger protection and improved visibility across the organization's digital infrastructure.